15,000 feet. This in itself was an unprecedented manoeuvre, but nevertheless brought home the necessity of having a light tank in our inventory akin to the Type-15 light tanks of the PLA, which were now ranged across us. Some activities had been spotted on the North Bank too, including about 500 PLA troops in riot gear assembling in an area about 500 m to the East of Finger 4. All these movements and probing actions made it apparent that something more was to happen. A whole Regiment worth of PLA tanks was lined up on the track leading up from their garrison towards Rechin La.

At 2015 hours on the evening of 31 August, Jo rang me up, quite worried. He reported that four tanks supported by infantry had slowly started moving up the track towards Rechin La. They had fired an illuminating round but this had had no effect. I had clear orders not to open fire, 'till cleared from the very top'. A flurry of calls followed, between the RM, EAM, NSA, CDS and myself over the next half-hour. To each and every one my question was, 'What are my orders?' At 2110 hours, Northern Command again rang up, the tanks had continued moving ahead and were now less than a km from the top. I rang up the RM again at 2125 hours, with the latest and once more asked for clear directions. The situation was tense. Telephone lines were buzzing. In the DGMO operations room, various options were being considered and discarded. The situation had to be monitored, not only at Rechin La/Eastern Ladakh but all across the Northern Front, including areas across Eastern Command. The entire Front was on high alert, especially at the known friction points.

Meanwhile, there had been an exchange of Hot Line messages. The PLA Commander, Maj Gen Liu Lin, suggested that both sides should stop any further move and that the two local commanders should meet at the pass at 0930 hours the

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